

CINDERELLA

by

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ACT I

SCENE 1

The living room of the family home. STEPHANIE and TIFFANY are sitting on the sofa in front of the television. Their clothes suggest two girls playing at princesses, but the dresses are faded and torn in places. They are wearing far too much makeup.

They are fighting over the remote control.

STEPHANIE: You got to watch Top Model last night. It's my turn to choose, and I'm choosing Master Chef.

TIFFANY: You know I can't watch Master Chef. It always makes me so hungry.

STEPHANIE: So what?

TIFFANY: I'm trying to stay skinny! How else will I ever get to be a model?

STEPHANIE: You'll never be a model stuck here on the sofa.

TIFFANY: Like you can talk.

STEPHANIE: Will you be quiet? I'm trying to watch this. They're making éclairs tonight.

TIFFANY: Éclairs!

TV (V/O): We interrupt this programme to bring you a very special announcement. As part of this week's royal birthday celebrations, Prince Handsome will be throwing a grand party, at the conclusion of which he has promised to choose a young woman to be his wife.

BOTH: His what?

TV (V/O): His wife. In a lavish and legally-binding ceremony to be held on his birthday, Prince Handsome will make one lucky guest very happy... and enormously rich and famous. Invitations should be arriving in letterboxes across the kingdom as we speak.

STEPHANIE: *(turning off the television)* Well, they've missed an opportunity there.

TIFFANY: What do you mean?

STEPHANIE: For a reality TV show. You know, like "Princess Idol".

TIFFANY: Or "Next Top Princess".

ELLA enters, dressed in torn jeans and a faded t-shirt, and carrying the mail. She's reading a gilt-edged invitation on lavish, cream-coloured parchment, but she's visibly unimpressed.

ELLA: Who wants to be a princess?

STEPHANIE: Nah, that'll never sell.

ELLA: What?

TIFFANY: Too negative. Is that the mail?

ELLA: Yeah. Looks like we're invited to some fancy party at the palace.

STEPHANIE: Give me that!

She snatches the invitation from ELLA'S hand. TIFFANY reads over her shoulder. ELLA starts picking up the dirty dishes and empty chip packets from around the room.

STEPHANIE: It is true!

TIFFANY: We're all invited. You, me, mum... even Grubby Ella.

STEPHANIE: Ha! Can you imagine Grubby Ella at a ball?

BOTH: *(Chanting)*
Grubby Ella, dressed in brown
Tried to dance, but just fell down
Did a jig with a big fat pig
And a stinky old bird's nest for a wig

The two sisters nearly wet themselves with laughter.

TIFFANY: Ha ha! Grubby Ella!

ELLA: (without looking up) I told you not to call me that.

STEPHANIE: Then clean yourself up a bit.

ELLA: I would, but I'm too busy cleaning up after you two selfish pigs.

TIFFANY: Selfish?

STEPHANIE: Pigs?

BOTH: We're telling mum!

ELLA: Tell her, then. See if I care.

The two sisters rush out of the room, clamouring for parental intervention. ELLA sighs and carries on tidying.

ELLA: I could almost stand living with those two if it wasn't for the constant mess. But I guess they're too busy watching TV and stuffing their faces to help. I mean, it's not hard to put your dirty clothes in the basket, or rinse your plates for the dishwasher.

ELLA puts on an apron with the words "I AM THE DISHWASHER" and begins to clean up.

She goes to pick up a mug: it's stuck to the plate underneath it, and she lifts the whole assembly off the table (in fact, perhaps she even lifts up the table), staring at it in horror.

ELLA: Ugh. I wonder how long that's been there?

She places the whole thing back down gingerly and flops onto the sofa.

ELLA: Just once, it would be nice to have some time to myself, to do the things that I want to do. I'm always so busy cooking, or cleaning, or ironing, or vacuuming... but what I really want to do is start my own business. I've been doing some sketches...

She pulls a sketchpad out from under the sofa. It's filled with pictures of...

ELLA: Shoes! Comfortable, practical, elegant shoes. No high heels, or fiddly laces, just the most comfortable shoes you've ever worn. So light you hardly notice they're there, but smart and stylish enough for any occasion. Like... like slippers you can wear to meet the queen.

She realises she's getting carried away, and stops herself.

ELLA: So, anyway. That's my dream. It'll never happen, though. Not while I'm stuck here. Although, if the others were out of my hair, even for an evening... Maybe this party could be my chance to spend some time by myself!

DAPHNE: *(off)* Ella!

ELLA: *(hiding the sketchbook quickly)* I'm in here!

DAPHNE enters, holding the invitation.

DAPHNE: Did you call your sisters "selfish pigs"?

ELLA: They're not my real sisters.

DAPHNE: That's no excuse for poor manners, young lady. We're each of us a part of this family.

ELLA: *(sotto voce)* Maybe they should start acting like it.

DAPHNE: What was that?

ELLA: Nothing.

DAPHNE: Nothing what?

ELLA: Nothing, mother.

DAPHNE: That's better. Now: about this ball...

She brandishes the invitation.

ELLA: I know, I know: I have to stay here and clean the house.

DAPHNE: Actually, Ella: I've decided you shall go to the ball.

ELLA: No, really, I don't mind...

DAPHNE: (*ignoring her*) After all, I'm too old to marry the Prince, and if you were to... catch his eye, you'd be in a much better position to take care of me in my old age.

ELLA: But I don't want...

DAPHNE: Of course, we'll need to spruce you up a bit, but just leave that to me. Well? What do you say?

ELLA: I--

DAPHNE: Oh, no need to thank me, dear. It's a mother's duty. Now, what's for dinner?

ELLA is speechless.

DAPHNE: You haven't started yet, have you? Well, hop to it, dear: we're all absolutely starving.

ELLA: (*sotto*) What's new?

DAPHNE: What was that?

ELLA: Nothing, mother.

DAPHNE: Good girl.

She kisses ELLA on the forehead, then spits and sputters, and makes a show of picking a speck of dirt off her lips.

DAPHNE: And have a bath, would you? You're filthy, child.

She exits. ELLA sighs, looks around at the messy lounge, and carries on cleaning up.

ACT I

SCENE 2

The next morning. Back in a relatively tidy living room, DAPHNE is examining scrapbooks and swatches over coffee with MIRANDA MERRIWEATHER, a local stylist and school friend.

DAPHNE: *(holding up a swatch)* I was thinking of something in a cornflower blue, perhaps with a little tiara?

MIRANDA: Dear me, no. Blue is so last season. And a tiara? Well, thank goodness you called me, dear, is all I can say. *(Chuckling to herself)* Cornflower blue. Oh, my.

ELLA enters, laden with groceries. She's wearing the same clothes she was wearing to clean the house the night before.

DAPHNE: Ella! Where have you been?

ELLA: *(gesturing with the groceries, her arms still full)* I've been to the market!

MIRANDA: Good heavens! Looking like that?

ELLA: I'm sorry: who are you?

DAPHNE: Ella! What a terrible thing to say!

She takes the groceries from ELLA and puts them on the floor, then leads ELLA downstage, away from the groceries, into the area where she and MIRANDA have been discussing her outfit for the ball.

STEPHANIE and TIFFANY pounce on the groceries, rooting noisily through the bags until they find packets of chocolate biscuits, iced buns, or similar (for STEPHANIE) and celebrity gossip magazines (for TIFFANY), then leave again, holding their prizes aloft in triumph.

DAPHNE: This is my very good friend Miranda Merriweather, of Miranda Merriweather's Miraculous Magical Makeovers.

ELLA: Oh, I'm sorry. (*pleasantly, curtseying*) I didn't see your broom outside.

MIRANDA: My dear, I'm not a witch. I'm a style consultant with magical abilities.

DAPHNE: Ella, Miranda is my oldest friend, and she's agreed to do me the not inconsiderable favour of transforming you into something approximating a young lady of society and manners. The least you could do is show a little gratitude.

ELLA: I -- yes, mother. Thank you, Ms Merriweather.

DAPHNE: Good girl.

MIRANDA sizes ELLA up, pinching her cheek.

MIRANDA: Now, Ella: Daphne tells me there's a party you wish to attend at the palace.

ELLA: Well, actually...

MIRANDA: Never fear, my dear: you shall go to the ball!

ELLA: But I don't --

DAPHNE: (*with finality*) You shall go to the ball.

MIRANDA: Precisely, darling. Good. Excellent. So: let's begin, shall we? Where are my assistants?

MIRANDA selects two assistants from the audience. Together, they create an outfit for Ella, seemingly out of nothing at all, and help her into it. The items of costume should be hidden around the set, and 'revealed' in a magical fashion: perhaps tricky parts of the 'transformation' could take place behind a blanket held up by the assistants.

The image that results is of an utterly beautiful ball gown -- elegant and stylish without being tacky -- and someone inside it who has absolutely no desire to be there, and who suits it not a bit. It is the gown, in fact, that DAPHNE wishes she could wear to the ball.

MIRANDA: Perfect. Now: transportation. Your entrance is everything, my dear, and it's important you arrive in style.

She lifts the cover off a large cage, containing four white mice, a large brown rat, and a bright green lizard.

ELLA: Mice? A rat? And... what's that? A lizard?

MIRANDA: As I said, my dear: transportation is very important. These mice are the horses that will pull your coach; the rat is Ralph, your coachman; and the lizard is your footman, Lewis.

ELLA: Wait: my coach?

MIRANDA: Ah yes, my dear. Daphne, hand me that pumpkin, would you?

DAPHNE fetches a large pumpkin from the grocery bag.

ELLA: I was going to make soup with that!

DAPHNE: Dear child, what's more important? Soup for one meal, or becoming a princess and having servants to cook soup for you (and your poor stepmother) for the rest of your life?

MIRANDA: Well said, Daphne! You see, Ella? Your mother really does have your best interests at heart.

She produces four cardboard wheels and pins them to the side of the pumpkin.

MIRANDA: Voilà! One coach, fit for a princess.

There is a stunned silence from ELLA and DAPHNE.

DAPHNE: I have to say, Miranda, you should probably stick to fashion.

ELLA: How am I supposed to ride that to the ball?

MIRANDA: Patience, dear. Things are not always as they seem. I'm sure you shall find my arrangements more than adequate to the task, come Saturday night. Now, run along: I'm sure you have chores to attend to.

ELLA: Yes, Ms Merriweather.

DAPHNE: Ahem.

ELLA: Thank you, Ms Merriweather.

MIRANDA: That's quite alright, child.

ELLA gathers up the groceries and makes to leave.

MIRANDA: Just a moment! Aren't you forgetting something?

ELLA realises she means the cage. She struggles to pick it up, and stumbles through the door.

MIRANDA and DAPHNE watch her leave.

MIRANDA: My word, Daphne, she's quite a handful.

DAPHNE: Well, I'm stuck with her until I can marry her off.

MIRANDA: Quite right, dear. And if you should happen to do well out of the whole affair...

DAPHNE: Exactly. Tell you what, I can't wait to get out of this dump.

MIRANDA: I quite understand. Don't you have a maid?

DAPHNE gestures after ELLA.

MIRANDA: I see. Well, free help is never the best. Speaking of which...

DAPHNE: Oh, Miranda, yes: I can't tell you how grateful I am.

MIRANDA: Not at all, my love. You're my oldest friend: it's the least I could do. However, I should perhaps just point out that if Ella's not home by midnight, the enchantments will -- I'm so sorry about this -- wear off. With what I have to work with (*she nods towards the door*), it's all I can do.

DAPHNE: Miranda, if she's not home by midnight, she'll have bigger problems than a pumpkin.

MIRANDA laughs.

MIRANDA: Oh, my dear, you're simply too much.

They pack up MIRANDA's swatches and exit.

ACT I

SCENE 3

ELLA's modest bedroom. There is a bed, a full-length mirror, and not much else. The cage containing the animals sits on the floor, and they watch the following scene with papier-mâché interest.

ELLA stands in front of the mirror, turning this way and that, and tugging dubiously at the skirt of her new ball gown, as if she is almost hoping that she can will it to turn back into a pair of jeans and a t-shirt. She makes a genuine, if clumsy, attempt at a gracious curtsy and a "charmed, Your Highness", before collapsing onto her bed in frustration.

ELLA: I look ridiculous. I feel ridiculous. And these shoes. Are. Awful.

She tugs off the delicate high heels and throws them into a corner.

ELLA: I couldn't stand up in those shoes for five minutes, let alone dance in them all evening. What I need... A-ha!

She rummages under or behind the bed and produces a battered cardboard box full of her step-sisters' cast-off shoes, which have been modified with fabric, craft glue, cardboard, staples, and glitter: a child's attempt at realising her dream career, constrained by limited materials, no budget, and the necessity of absolute secrecy. There are shoes with wings; shoes with small plastic toys glued to the toes; shoes with parts of other shoes attached.

ELLA holds each shoe up in turn, showing it to the animals in the cage (and to the audience), and explaining its features and purpose with mounting enthusiasm.

She is so caught up in the thrill of her work that she forgets she doesn't want to go to the ball: in fact, it's become an urgent need. ELLA is her own first client, and the perfect ball shoe her first commission.

ELLA: Never be late for another appointment with the Quick-Step: the shoe with the built-in alarm clock!

Tread lightly with new Featherlite Boots (not for the ticklish)!

Clumsy? Try the Sure-Foot!

Can't dance? We have pairs with two left feet!

And so on.

ELLA: Hmm. None of these is just right for the ball. But all of them are a little bit right.

She picks up the Quick-Step and checks the time.

ELLA: It's late, but not too late. If I work hard, and don't sleep, I should be able to cobble something together before the ball, and still get all my chores done.

She produces scissors, glue, and a threaded needle from the box, and sets to work.

ACT I

SCENE 4

The next evening. STEPHANIE and TIFFANY are swanning about in the kitchen, dressed in beautiful gowns and wearing even more makeup than usual.

TIFFANY: I've been practising my fancy talking for the ball. Listen: *(in a fancy accent)* air.

STEPHANIE: *(unaccented)* Air.

TIFFANY: No: air.

STEPHANIE: Air-uh.

TIFFANY: *(sigh)* One more try. *(to the audience)* Everybody: air.

EVERYBODY: Air.

TIFFANY: Good! Hair.

EVERYBODY: Hair.

TIFFANY: Lair.

EVERYBODY: Lair.

TIFFANY: There.

EVERYBODY: There.

TIFFANY effects a clumsy curtsy.

TIFFANY: Air, hair-lair there!

STEPHANIE: *(catching on; fancy)* Air, hair-lair there!
(then, in her regular voice) Pretty fancy party, eh?

TIFFANY: *(despairingly)* We'll work on it in the helicopter.

ELLA enters, in her gown.

ELLA: Helicopter?

STEPHANIE: Nothing!

TIFFANY: Helicopter? What?

STEPHANIE: Byeeee!

They hurry off. There is a loud noise as a helicopter takes off.

ELLA: Oh, man! Helicopter?

LEWIS enters from the opposite side of the stage. He is wearing green, and is awkward around ELLA.

LEWIS: Ahem.

ELLA: Yes?

LEWIS: Your coach, m'lady.

ELLA: But you're...

LEWIS bows.

LEWIS: Lewis, m'lady.

ELLA: *(aside)* The lizard! *(To LEWIS)* And where are the, um...

LEWIS: The mice? Ah, yes.

LEWIS selects four 'mice' (older children) and a 'rat' from the audience, and gives them appropriate items of costume to suggest four horses (ostrich plumes?) and a coachman (a surplice?)

LEWIS: And now the coach. Just a moment, m'lady.

He leads the horses and coachman off.

ELLA: Well, I suppose a coach isn't so bad. It might actually be pretty exciting.

She stalls until the 'coach' enters. It's actually just the pumpkin, on top of a stage truck, pulled by the horses. The coachman stands to one side, encouraging the horses.

ELLA stares in disbelief.

LEWIS: Sorry about that, m'lady. Miz Miranda's enchantments can sometimes be a tad... unreliable.

ELLA: Ella.

LEWIS: I'm sorry?

ELLA: Call me Ella.

LEWIS: Yes, m'lady.

ELLA: Ahem.

LEWIS: Ella. Oh. Er, just one thing, m--Ella. Has anyone told you... what happens at midnight?

ELLA: No. What happens at midnight?

LEWIS: Well, let's just say me and the lads here are off the clock, like.

ELLA: "Off the clock"?

LEWIS: And you might find yourself setting some startling new trends in fashion.

ELLA: "Startling new trends..." *(She sighs heavily)* Lewis! Will you please just say what you mean?

LEWIS: Well, it's simple. At midnight, he goes back to being a rat, they're mice, I'm a lizard, you're back in your old clothes, and that's just a pumpkin.

ELLA: It's just a pumpkin now!

LEWIS: *(panicking)* It's starting already?

ELLA shows him the pumpkin.

Oh. Right.

ELLA: So I have to be home by midnight from the party I'm still not convinced I want to go to? I think I can handle that. Alright, Lewis: let's do this.

She climbs aboard the truck and holds the pumpkin under one arm.

LEWIS: Are you sure --

ELLA: To the ball!

Very slowly and carefully, LEWIS and the 'horses' escort the truck off stage, and LEWIS returns the audience volunteers to their seats.

REVIEW COPY

ACT I

SCENE 5

The palace has been decked out for the grand ball. PRINCE HANDSOME is standing in the ballroom with MIRANDA. Fancy music (probably Vivaldi) is playing.

PRINCE: I must say, Miranda: I love what you've done with the place.

MIRANDA: Oh, Your Highness is too kind!

PRINCE: Oh, I'm sorry. Ahem. I must say, Miranda: I'm a bit disappointed with these decorations.

MIRANDA: Thank you, Your Highness.

PRINCE: Not at all, Miranda. Now, where are the ladies?

He looks expectantly offstage. There is the sound of a helicopter landing. STEPHANIE and TIFFANY enter, adjusting their hair, which has been ruined by the turbulence from the helicopter. DAPHNE enters behind them.

PRINCE: That was easy! Hmm. Now, where's the chocolate pudding?

He looks offstage again, but no pudding materialises. The PRINCE looks crestfallen.

PRINCE: Well, it was worth a try. Laaaaaadies!

He saunters over to them.

Welcome to my fancy party!

They curtsey politely.

Oh, yes! Where are my manners?

He curtseys deeply. STEPHANIE and TIFFANY look at each other confusedly, as MIRANDA hurries over and whispers in the PRINCE's ear.

Really? Well, I suppose, if you're sure that's...

He executes a courtly bow. The girls clap their hands and giggle delightedly.

Ah, yes. That's better.

DAPHNE: Your Highness, allow me to present my daughters, Stephanie and Tiffany.

PRINCE: Charmed, I'm sure. *(To TIFFANY, kissing her hand)* Stephanie. *(To STEPHANIE, likewise)* Tiffany.

STEPHANIE: I'm Stephanie.

TIFFANY: I'm Tiffany.

PRINCE: Well, you're both beautiful. Let's dance!

He leads them onto the floor, and he and DAPHNE take a girl each, and begin teaching the audience a simple partner dance, arranged in such a way that the couples are swapped over occasionally. As the music plays and they dance, ELLA enters and stands, watching. DAPHNE notices, and beckons her over, swapping her into the dance so that eventually she is face to face with the PRINCE, who stops immediately.

PRINCE: Stop! Everybody! *(To the audience)* You! All sit down! *(To ELLA)* You! Who are you?

DAPHNE: Your highness, allow--

PRINCE: Quiet! *(To ELLA)* Well?

ELLA: My name's Ella.

DAPHNE, watching with fascination, remembers to cough loudly.

ELLA: ...Your Highness.

PRINCE: Well, Ella-Your-Highness: you're the most beautiful girl I've ever met. Let's get married and live happily ever after.

STEPHANIE AND TIFFANY:

Her?

ELLA: Me?

PRINCE: Well, what do you say?

ELLA: No thanks.

DAPHNE: What?

ELLA: Well, it's just that... I only just met you, and I'm a bit young to get married anyway, and I'm not really a princess like you seem to think, and --

PRINCE: I don't care about any of that stuff! The law of the land says that I can ask any girl I like to be my wife!

ELLA: But it doesn't say I have to say yes!

She stares at him for a moment, then turns and runs out, leaving a stunned silence in her wake. DAPHNE motions to the remaining sisters, who sidle up to the PRINCE.

TIFFANY: Come on, Your Highness.

STEPHANIE: I hear they have those little spring rolls at the supper table.

TIFFANY looks askance at STEPHANIE.

STEPHANIE: What? Dancing makes me hungry.

They lead the dazed PRINCE away. DAPHNE and MIRANDA follow at a discreet distance, whispering conspiratorially.

ACT I

SCENE 6

Outside the palace. LEWIS is leaning against a wall, polishing the pumpkin with a soft cloth, and humming to himself. Any pretense of formality he had as a footman is gone: he is clearly off-duty.

There is a buzzing sound. LEWIS puts the pumpkin down carefully, and tracks the source of the noise with his eyes, then suddenly snatches a fly out of the air with his tongue. He makes a disgusted face as he chews and swallows.

He picks up the pumpkin and resumes his polishing as ELLA enters, composing herself. He straightens up as he sees her, but softens kindly at her discombobulation.

LEWIS: Miss Ella! Back already?

ELLA snuffles and flops against the wall beside LEWIS.

LEWIS: That bad, eh?

He looks down at the cloth in his hand, shrugs, and hands it to ELLA, who blows her nose loudly.

ELLA: Thanks.

She offers the cloth back to LEWIS, who looks at it dubiously.

LEWIS: You hang on to that, miss. Want to talk about it?

ELLA: Oh, it's silly, really. Just... not really my thing.

LEWIS: Oh?

ELLA: Everyone's pretending to be people they're not, just so the prince will notice them.

ELLA (cont'd): The worst thing is, the prince doesn't even care if you are who you say you are! He's only interested in what you look like.

LEWIS: Oh, that's no kind of attitude at all! Everyone knows appearances can be deceptive.

ELLA: I know! I mean, take you, for example! You're a... well, you're a...

LEWIS: A footman?

ELLA: A lizard!

LEWIS: Only kind of.

ELLA: What? How can you be "kind of" a lizard?

LEWIS: I ain't always been a lizard, miss. I used to be a cobbler. Making shoes, like.

ELLA: Shoes?

LEWIS: 'sright, miss. Had me own shop an' everything. Lew's Leather'n'Laces. Nothing fancy, mind, just starting out: but it was mine.

ELLA: I love shoes!

LEWIS: Well, what young lady doesn't?

ELLA: No, I mean, I really love shoes! Look!

ELLA lifts up the hem of her dress, and reveals a magnificent shoe, arrayed with gadgets, attachments, and decorations. She reaches down and undoes a shoe, takes it off, and hands it to LEWIS, who whistles appreciatively, inspecting it.

LEWIS: Miss Ella! I've seen some shoes in my time, but this is quality! Adjustable cushioning! Pressure sensors! Self-tightening laces! Retractable tread! High-visibility reflective panels for evening wear! Where'd you say you picked this up?

ELLA: I... I made it myself.

LEWIS: You never.

ELLA: I didn't know quite what to expect this evening, so I wanted to be prepared for anything.

LEWIS: A very wise attitude, Miss Ella. Very wise.

LEWIS hands the shoe back, and ELLA places it down, but does not put it back on.

ELLA: Anyway, where were we? You were telling me about your shoe business.

LEWIS: Well, one day I'm round Miz Miranda's, sub-contracting, like. She always has trouble with the shoes. Anyway, she gets word her regular footman's taken ill, and would I mind filling in? I thought to myself, well, I'm a foot man of a sort anyway: where's the harm? Only there must be some kind of magic in the uniform, because when I try to take it off at the end of the night to go home, there's a flash of green light, and I find myself in a cage, looking up at the old woman, who's cackling away. The rat filled me in on things: terms and conditions of employment, you might say.

ELLA: Employment? You mean, she's kept you there as a prisoner ever since?

LEWIS: Oh, she was never unkind to us. Apart from turning us into lizards and mice and that. Hours of work are very reasonable, food and board provided --

ELLA: In a cage! This is outrageous! Come on, Lewis: we're going to go right back in there and make her set you free.

ELLA picks up her shoe in one hand and grabs LEWIS's arm with the other.

LEWIS: Well, you'd best hurry, miss.

ELLA: What do you mean?

LEWIS: It's five minutes to midnight.

They rush off.

ACT I

SCENE 7

Back in the ballroom. STEPHANIE is standing at the buffet table, behind a huge plate of hors d'oeuvres: for each one she eats, she hands another to TIFFANY, who is sitting on a little sofa in front of the table with the PRINCE, feeding him cutesily. The image is that of an assembly line.

Across the room, DAPHNE and MIRANDA are getting tipsy on free champagne, and planning DAPHNE's future as a kind of Queen Mother figure.

MIRANDA: ...and the hats you'll have, my dear! You'll need a separate palace just for hats, I shouldn't wonder.

DAPHNE: Miranda, it's my daughter marrying the prince, not me!

MIRANDA: And what daughter would be so callous, so ungrateful as to forget her mother's efforts -- and the efforts of her mother's very dearest friends, of course -- in providing her with such an opportunity?

At that moment, there is a loud bang and a flash of green light from off stage. ELLA stumbles in in rags, with a shoe in one hand and -- alas! -- a lizard in the other.

ELLA: Ahem. Your Highness!

The PRINCE doesn't look up.

PRINCE: *(Mouth full)* Go away. I'm busy.

ELLA: Your Highness, I demand an audience!

PRINCE: I said I'm --

He looks up.

Who are you?

ELLA: Oh, so you don't remember me now that my fancy clothes have disappeared?

PRINCE: Are you one of the servants?

ELLA: Not anymore! Your Highness, I come to you not as a guest at your party, but as a citizen. I wish to expose a terrible crime: kidnapping, imprisonment, forced labour bordering on slavery...

MIRANDA steps quickly forward and takes ELLA by the shoulders.

MIRANDA: Really, child! After all Daphne has done for you--

But ELLA shrugs her off.

ELLA: I speak, of course, of the disappearance of Lewis, lately the proprietor of Lew's Leather'n'Laces, turned into a lizard and kept prisoner by this woman, Miranda Merriweather.

MIRANDA blanches. There is a terrible silence. Then the Prince lets out a guffaw.

PRINCE: A lizard? What could Miranda possibly want with a lizard? I suppose this is the creature? Told you the story himself, did he?

ELLA: Well, yes, actually he --

PRINCE: Get out of my party, you smelly little tramp, and take that repulsive, slimy thing with you.

ELLA: But, Your High--

MIRANDA knows an opening when she sees one.

MIRANDA: Come, child! Can't you see His Highness is entertaining guests? He hasn't time for your silly fantasies and baseless allegations.

ELLA: Oh, go and boil your bum, you old witch!

ELLA brandishes the shoe at MIRANDA, who cowers back a little; then, seeing that the PRINCE has resumed ignoring her, hesitates only a fraction of a second before hurling it at his back and hurrying from the room, still clutching the lizard.

PRINCE: Hmm? Oh! A shoe!

He picks it up and begins to examine it.

DAPHNE, who has been watching this exchange with mounting interest, darts forward and snatches the shoe, remembering her manners just in time.

DAPHNE: Thank you, Your Highness.

PRINCE: Oh, yes. Quite alright.

DAPHNE stands for a moment, examining the shoe from every angle.

MIRANDA: Daphne?

She says nothing.

MIRANDA: Surely you don't believe --

DAPHNE: Quiet, Miranda. I think I need to have a talk with my step-daughter.

ACT I

SCENE 8

Outside the palace. Ella is sitting on a step, forlorn.

ELLA: It's not fair, Lewis. You're the only person here worth talking to, and you can't even talk back because you're a lizard!

She begins to cry.

DAPHNE enters, cautiously.

DAPHNE: Ella?

ELLA: Go away.

DAPHNE: Ella, I want to talk to you.

ELLA: Well, I don't want to talk to you! Why did you make me come to this stupid ball in the first place? Everyone's so fake and awful, just because they want the Prince to like them, and he turns out to be the worst of all! Except maybe Miranda: she --

DAPHNE: I'm sorry.

ELLA: I -- what?

DAPHNE: I should have listened when you said you didn't want to come to the ball. I was just so sure I knew what you wanted: a party like this is all I could have dreamed of at your age. But you're not me, are you?

ELLA: No. I'm sorry. I know you want me to be, but I'm not.

DAPHNE: Don't be sorry. Never apologise for being who you are, Ella.

She puts an awkward arm around ELLA, who returns the gesture with a big hug.

Now: is this your shoe?

ELLA: I'm sorry! I just didn't want to wear the ones Miranda gave me. They were so hard and uncomfortable!

DAPHNE: I did think glass slippers was an odd choice. But wherever did you get these?

ELLA: (*hesitantly*) I... I made them.

DAPHNE: But how? How did you learn?

ELLA: I taught myself! At first, I just tried to copy shoes I saw other people wearing, but then I started to get my own ideas, and... well, I guess I get a bit carried away sometimes.

DAPHNE: And so you made all this...

ELLA: ...at night, mostly. After you'd gone to bed, when I had some time to myself.

DAPHNE: When you weren't doing the housework.

ELLA: When I wasn't doing all the housework.

DAPHNE: I'm sorry.

ELLA: Of course I want to help around the house: I really don't mind doing my share of the chores. It would just be just nice to have some time to myself, too.

DAPHNE: You're really serious about this shoe thing?

ELLA: Oh, mum! More than anything! And then I finally meet someone who could help me, and he turns out to be a lizard most of the time.

DAPHNE: Yes, what is the story there?

ELLA: It's horrible! The mice, the rat, Lewis: they're all really people, and Miranda keeps them prisoner!

DAPHNE allows LEWIS to crawl onto her arm and looks at him thoughtfully.

DAPHNE: But that's...

ELLA: It's awful! That's why I tried to ask the Prince for help, but he didn't seem to want to know about it.

DAPHNE: Well, someone's going to have to do something!

DAPHNE stands up as MIRANDA enters.

MIRANDA: Do something about what? Daphne, dear, you're missing all the --

DAPHNE: I'm spending some time with my daughter. And learning some very interesting information about your... employees.

MIRANDA: Now, Daphne, you're my oldest friend! Surely you don't believe...

As DAPHNE advances on MIRANDA, the latter begins to panic and draws her wand, pointing it shakily at DAPHNE.

DAPHNE snatches the wand and brandishes it at MIRANDA.

DAPHNE: Well, we're certainly going to find out.

Still holding LEWIS, DAPHNE chases MIRANDA off, leaving ELLA on stage.

ELLA: Mum? What are you --

MIRANDA: (off) Daphne, please!

There is a loud bang and a flash of green light. ELLA winces and covers her eyes, but when she opens them, DAPHNE enters.

ELLA: What did you do?

DAPHNE: Just sorting out your ride home, darling.

LEWIS enters, brushing himself off. He sees ELLA and tips an imaginary hat.

LEWIS: Miss Ella.

ELLA: Lewis!

She hugs him. DAPHNE clears her throat loudly and she disengages.

DAPHNE: I've asked Lewis to make sure you get home safely.

LEWIS: I'll see about that coach, Ma'am. (to ELLA) A proper one, this time.

He exits.

ELLA: What about you?

DAPHNE: I have two other daughters to disentangle, and Miranda's just fainted, so I have to sort her out. You'll be alright?

ELLA kisses DAPHNE on the cheek.

ELLA: Don't be too late. I'm making pancakes for breakfast.

DAPHNE: Sounds perfect. Goodnight, my dear.

DAPHNE exits.

REVIEW COPY

ACT I

SCENE 9

ELLA: Well, that's most of the excitement that night. Tiffany married Prince Handsome, of course, and you should have seen the wedding. It was like something out of a fairytale.

TIFFANY enters in a wedding dress, on the arm of her PRINCE. STEPHANIE walks behind them, throwing confetti.

ELLA: Stephanie didn't mind. She did the catering for the wedding, and loved it so much, she stayed on as head chef at the palace.

STEPHANIE takes a croissant out of the confetti basket and munches on it.

ELLA: I get on with them a lot better now we're not living together. Stephanie's job at the palace taught her a little bit about doing dishes, and I think Tiffany's learned a thing or two about what it means to be in the spotlight all the time.

LEWIS enters with a sandwich board reading "Lew's Leather'n'Laces: Grand re-opening sale!", which he sets up proudly.

ELLA: Lewis left his footman's job and went back to being a cobbler, and the demand for Lew's shoes was so great he took me on as an apprentice. I moved in to the city to be closer to the shop -- and, well, closer to Lewis.

ELLA blushes a little as she takes LEWIS's hand.

ELLA: With the three of us out of the house, you'd think Mum would have got a bit lonely. Don't worry though...

DAPHNE enters, carrying a fat white cat.

ELLA: ...she made sure Miranda stuck around.

DAPHNE scratches the cat behind the ears.

ELLA: And that's my story. Just remember: don't try
and be anybody you're not, because who you are
is just fine.

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THE END

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